

REVIEW

Do school smartphone bans improve grades and mental health?

REFERENCES	STYLE	MADE WITH	VERIFICATION	COMPILED
10 verified	Bullets	Grounded v4.1.0	Crossref	1 Sep 2026

SUMMARY

They reliably reduce phone access during school. Grades sometimes improve, especially in particular settings or groups, but equally credible studies find no gain. Broad mental-health benefits have not been shown, so a ban is a school rule, not a stand-alone wellbeing treatment.

01 Grades sometimes improve, but the average result is mixed

- >> An English policy study linked bans to a **0.07-standard-deviation** exam-score rise across 130,482 pupils, with the clearest gains among lower-achieving students.¹
- >> A Spanish regional analysis reported higher PISA performance after restrictions in one region, but the result did not repeat cleanly across both regions studied.²

- >> A Swedish national replication found no academic effect and could reject even small gains, while a South Australian rollout found no policy-specific improvement in academic engagement after one month.^{3,4}

Figure 1 keeps those results in proportion: the policy changes access first, while the two outcomes remain separate questions.

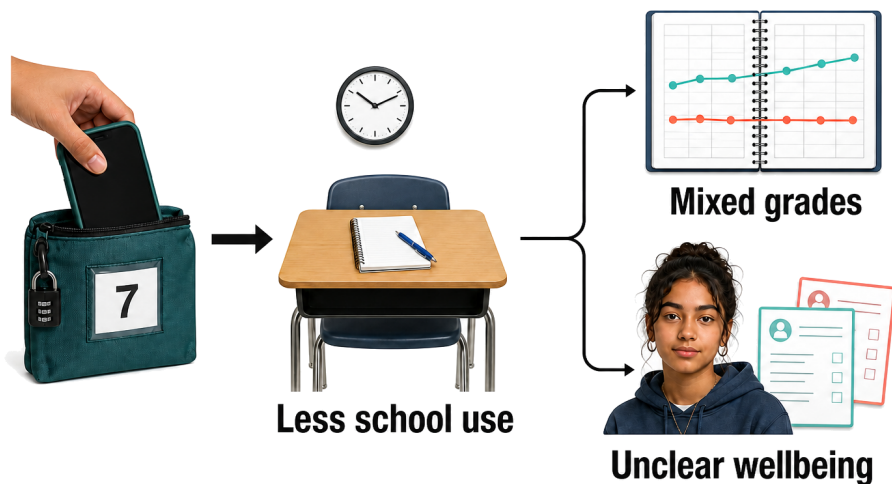


Figure 1. The rule is clearer than its downstream effects. Schools can make phones less available during the day. Academic studies point in both directions, and recent wellbeing comparisons do not show a dependable overall benefit.^{1,3,5}

02 Wellbeing has not improved reliably

- >> In 30 English schools, restrictive policies reduced in-school phone time by **0.67 hours**, but wellbeing was essentially unchanged (adjusted difference -0.48 points).⁵
- >> The South Australian rollout found no policy-specific gain in school belonging, and a Dutch comparison of 24 schools found no wellbeing or bullying advantage for full rather than partial bans.^{4,6}

- >> A newer emulated Australian trial reported modest psychological effects, but its authors positioned bans as one component of broader adolescent support rather than a complete mental-health response.⁷

03 “A ban” is not one standard intervention

- >> Full and classroom-only Dutch bans produced similar wellbeing outcomes; full bans were also associated with lower student-teacher connectedness and, for girls, lower school belonging.⁶

>> Interviews across seven English schools found positive and negative experiences shaped by enforcement, agency, relationships, learning needs, and what happened outside school.⁸

>> Figure 2 shows why the strongest link runs from a clear rule to less access; later links to grades or health depend on implementation and context.

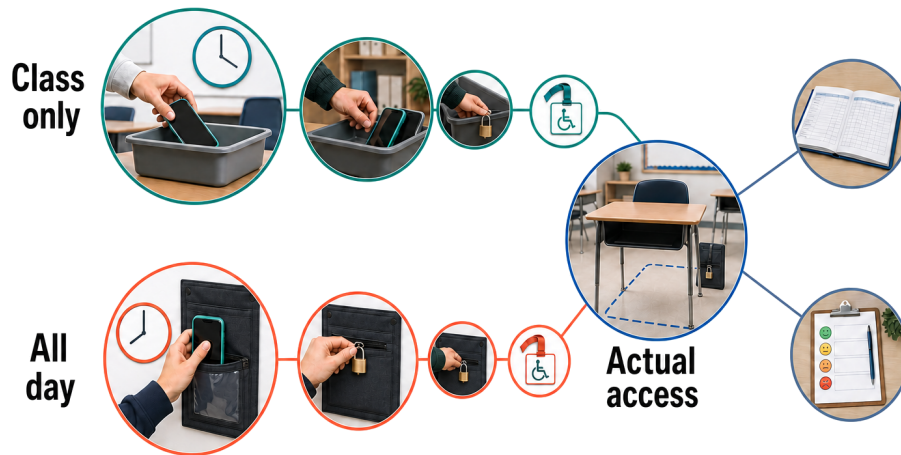


Figure 2. Policy labels do not reveal what pupils experience. Scope, enforcement, exemptions, and out-of-school displacement sit between the written rule and its hoped-for outcomes.^{5,8,6}

04 The evidence supports local goals, not universal promises

>> A preregistered scoping review found **22 studies** across 12 countries, no randomized school-policy trials, and major differences in ban definitions, samples, and outcomes.⁹

>> A rapid review of five policy studies estimated a positive overall direction, but its small and heterogeneous evidence base limits how confidently that average can guide one school.¹⁰

>> The practical pattern is consistent: measure the intended outcome directly. A school seeking fewer classroom interruptions should track use and disruption; one promising better grades or wellbeing should also track those outcomes, compliance, exclusions, and unintended effects.

MADE WITH GROUND

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- >> Every source from a live search; every DOI and retraction status checked against Crossref.
- >> Yours to run: github.com/jostelzer/grounded

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